



THE 5 SECOND RULE

Transform Your Life, Work, and Confidence
with Everyday Courage

Mel Robbins



The Big “So What”

This book presents a simple but powerful method to take decisive action, build confidence and courage, and achieve success in any area of life, 5 seconds at a time.



Unleashing Potential with the 5 Second Rule



The 5 Second Rule is a straightforward tool designed to combat doubt, fear, and hesitation. The Rule is simple: Once you have an impulse to act on a goal, you must push yourself to act within 5 seconds, before your brain has the chance to kill the idea.

- This rule operates as a metacognitive tool, tricking your brain into executing something you know you should do, but typically avoid.



You can use the Rule for virtually any aspect of your life. The key is to stop over-thinking and start taking action.

- By the time this book was published, more than 100,000 people globally had already benefited from the Rule. Robbins shares many social media excerpts and testimonials to show how you, too, can use the rule to:
 - (i) Improve health and wellness, e.g. going the gym or resisting junk food;
 - (ii) Advance your career aspirations, e.g. seizing opportunities to improve your skills/network, or asking for pay raise;
 - (iii) Improve productivity and results, e.g. stop procrastination, finish a degree, or improve your financial situation; and

KEY QUOTES

"If you're searching for that one person who will change your life look in the mirror."

"You change your life one five-second decision at a time."

"I was the problem and in five seconds, I could push myself and become the solution."

"Change comes down to the courage you need every day to make five second decisions."

(iv) Improve emotional regulation, e.g. calm down instead of snapping at others, stop excessive worrying, quit drinking, or manage depression.

- In this summary, we will start by explaining the 5 Second Rule, before elaborating on how to apply it to transform your life.



How Did The 5 Second Rule Come About?



Mel Robbins discovered the 5 Second Rule during a low point in her life, when she was struggling with financial troubles, a failing marriage, and career problems. She was filled with self-doubt and anxiety, and struggled to get out of bed each morning.

- One night, she saw a rocket launch countdown in a commercial, and felt inspired to adopt a similar approach to propel herself out of bed.
- The next morning, she counted down "5-4-3-2-1", then pushed herself out of bed. She soon found that the method also worked consistently to overcome inertia, fear, or hesitation in other aspects of her life. This became the now-popular "5 Second Rule".



Overthinking makes even the smallest action—be it speaking up at a meeting, asking for help, or saying "no"—seem scary and difficult. In face of a challenge, your response in the first 5 seconds can decide whether you hold back or take positive steps toward your goals.

- By pushing you to take action, the Rule helps you to learn new things about yourself and unleash your inherent potential. The more you take action in spite of your fear and doubt, the more confident you become, and the more it builds your propensity for action, creating a virtuous cycle.
- By contrast, the more you succumb to your fears and excuses, the more it reinforces your sense of inadequacy or self-doubt, holding you back in a vicious cycle.

KEY QUOTES

"When it comes to change, goals, and dreams, you have to bet on yourself. That bet starts with hearing the instinct to change and honoring that instinct with action."

"The Rule will work every time you use it. But you have to use it."

"Pushing yourself to take simple actions creates a chain reaction in your confidence and your productivity."



Scientific Foundations of the 5 Second Rule



When and how do you use the 5 Second Rule? Use the Rule whenever you feel the impulse to do something you know is good for you, yet feel uncertain or hesitant about. Just count backward "5-4-3-2-1-GO". The moment you hit "GO", act immediately.



Some people dismiss the 5 Second Rule because it seems too simple to be useful. Yet, this Rule is backed by science.

- It's human nature to avoid risk and change. Given a chance, the brain will generate excuses to maintain status quo, and such thoughts grow louder with time. So, the key is to push yourself to take action *before* the fear-laden thoughts even begin.
- The counting is crucial to keep your mind focused on the task at hand, so it doesn't get the chance to start conjuring objections and hurdles. Having said that, counting forward doesn't work, as the numbers can run in perpetuity. You must count backward, so there's a finite end-point when you hit "1".
- It doesn't matter how you feel at the end of the countdown. Just act regardless, because the first step will generate a chain reaction.
 - (i) When you take physical action, your physiology changes, and excuses melt away. The more you take action, the more confident and productive you feel. The small steps accumulate to create a *massive compound effect*. You feel more in control of your life, which gives you even more motivation to keep going.
 - (ii) Over time, you form *new habits* with a bias for proactive action. Instead of getting paralyzed by analysis, or reacting passively to circumstances, you become more proactive and open to try new things.
- In psychology, the "Golden Rule of Habits" says that to change any habit, you must replace one behavioral pattern with another. The best way to counteract hesitation is to use it as a cue for action. Use it to concurrently:

KEY QUOTES

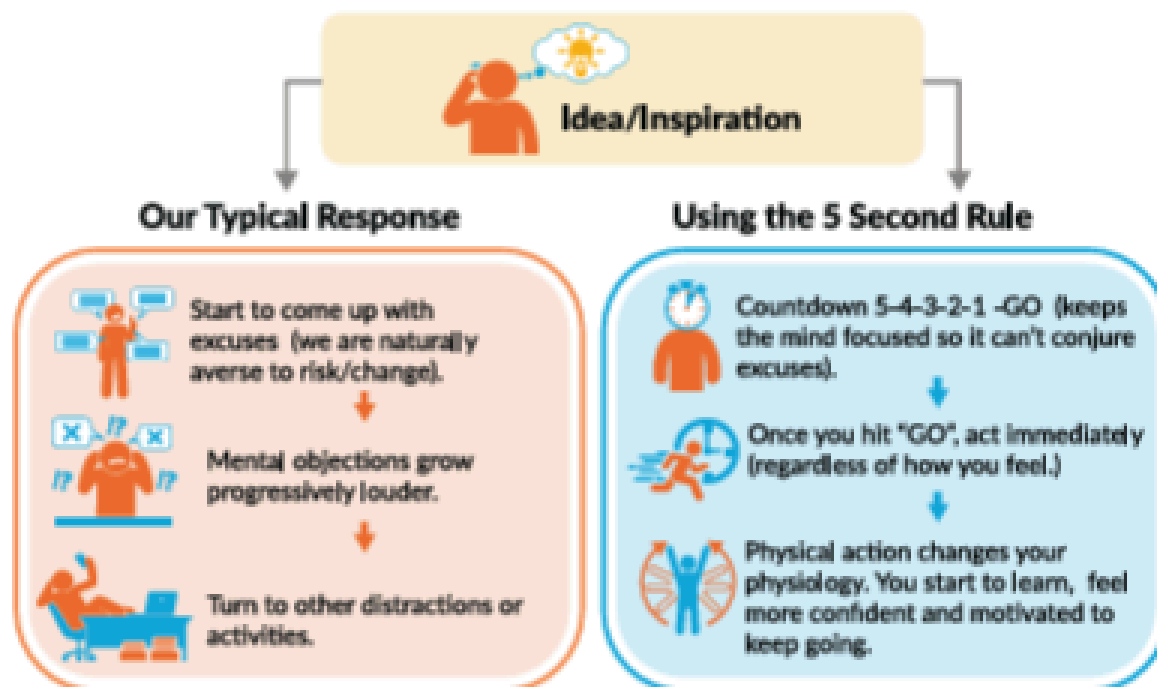
"The Rule doesn't make things easy; it makes them happen. That's why I describe it as a tool."

"Start before you're ready. Don't prepare. Begin."

"Starting rituals interrupt your bad default patterns and trigger new, positive patterns."

- (i) Break old habits of procrastinating, overthinking, or giving in to self-doubt and fear; and
- (ii) Build new habits of taking action in spite of uncertainty.

- As you use the countdown system repeatedly, you are essentially reprogramming your mind.



Transforming Your Life, 5 Seconds at a Time

 At first glance, the 5 Second Rule sounds similar to Nike's "Just Do It" slogan. However, "Just Do It" is a concept or a philosophy, whereas the Rule is a tool to push yourself to do what you need to do. It concurrently serves as a framework, a method, and a source of courage.



The Power of Courage

 Courage doesn't have to involve monumental actions or changes. It could involve simple acts like writing a book, asking for a pay raise, quitting drugs, or approaching someone attractive. In fact, small daily actions can lead to big changes.

- For example, Rosa Parks, a seamstress from Alabama, became a central figure in the American civil rights movement. On December 1, 1955, after a long day at work, Parks boarded a city bus and sat in the section designated for colored passengers. As the bus filled up, the driver demanded that

KEY QUOTES

"If you master the Rule you will reprogram your mind. You will teach yourself new behavior patterns."

"Change your decisions and you'll change your life. And what will change your decisions more than anything? Courage."

"Every single day we face moments that are difficult, uncertain, and scary. Your life requires courage. And...the Rule will help you discover the courage to become your greatest self."

she give up her seat to a white passenger. Parks refused and was arrested. Her act of defiance led to the formation of the Montgomery Improvement Association (led by Martin Luther King Jr), and galvanized the civil rights movement.

- Both Parks and King emerged as icons of the movement. They acted on spontaneous impulses to resist injustice, without prior planning. Had they considered the risks, their resolve might have wavered.



All of us have experienced similar moments when we feel a strong urge to act, whether it's reaching out to a friend in need, speaking up in a meeting, or embarking on a meaningful project. Yet, we hold back.

- The 5 Second Rule empowers us to overcome this hesitation. It spurs action that can lead us down a totally different path than if we had remained passive.



There's no "perfect time" to act. The right time to act is now.

- Consider these 2 examples:
 - (i) Michelangelo is renowned for painting the Sistine Chapel. Yet, when he was approached by the Pope in 1506, he initially rejected the project and fled to Florence out of self-doubt. He only started the job after 2 years of persistent requests by the Pope.
 - (ii) In 1977, Steve Jobs and Steve Wozniak received an investment offer to launch Apple Computers. Wozniak was initially too scared to quit his job, and only made the leap after strong encouragement from Jobs, friends, and family.
- By hesitating, what opportunities are you missing? Don't waste your life waiting for the perfect moment. Your biggest regrets are more likely to come from inaction than from failed actions. Ask yourself: What are you waiting for? What if your concerns are wrong? And, even if your fears came true, so what?



Ultimately, success is a numbers game. The more you do something, the more likely you'll succeed.

- Your actions might not guarantee success, but inaction ensures failure. Keep moving forward until you arrive at your goals. For example:

KEY QUOTES

"Courage is found in unlikely places."

– J.R.R. Tolkien

"I have learned over the years that when one's mind is made, this diminishes fear; knowing what must be done does away with fear."

– Rosa Parks

"If you have the courage to start, you have the courage to succeed."

"There is no right time. There is only right now. You get one life. This is it. And it's not going to begin again."

"The only thing that will quiet the chatter in your head is a decision to move."

"When you push yourself, you may not change the world... but I can guarantee you'll change something equally as important—you'll change yourself."

"The difference between people who make their dreams come true and those of us who don't is just one thing: the courage to start and the discipline to keep going."

- (i) Mobile game developer Rovio launched 51 unsuccessful games before hitting a home run with Angry Birds.
- (ii) Actor Mark Ruffalo auditioned for almost 600 roles (without being hired) before he landed the lead role in the Avengers.
- (iii) James Dyson created 5,127 prototypes before he arrived at the design for his iconic vacuum cleaner.
- (iv) Picasso is famous for 100 art masterpieces, but he actually created >50,000 art pieces in his lifetime, most of which were not considered to be masterpieces.



Taking Action Regardless of How You Feel



Neuroscientist Antonio Damasio found that 95% of our decisions are driven by emotions, not logic.

- When we make a decision, we're actually asking "Do I feel like doing this?", not "Should I do this?" Change is so hard because our feelings tend to get in the way, even if we know logically that it's good for us.
- The 5 Second Rule effectively separates emotions from actions, pushing you to act despite your feelings.
 - (i) If you feel too tired to go to the gym, just 5-4-3-2-1 and do it anyway.
 - (ii) If you feel like your idea isn't good enough, just 5-4-3-2-1 and share it anyway.
- It takes more energy to get out a state of inertia than to keep moving. Once you take action, it generates a burst of activation energy that makes it easier to keep moving ahead. In the process, you generate even more momentum.



The best way to start applying the Rule is to set your alarm 30 minutes earlier than usual, then use the 5-4-3-2-1 countdown to get out of bed immediately.

- This is effective because:
 - (i) There's no grey area: you're either up 30 minutes earlier, or not.

KEY QUOTES

"Courage is the commitment to begin without any guarantee of success."
- Johann Wolfgang Von Goeth

"If you only act when you feel like it, you will never get what you want."

"Whether you think you can or you can't, you're right."
- Henry Ford

"You can't control how you feel. But you can always choose how you act. Confidence is a skill that you build through action."

"That's how confidence grows—one small, courageous move at a time."

(ii) Once you change your morning routine, it gives you the confidence to change anything in your life.

(iii) You'll personally experience the power of activation energy, and realize how easy it is to keep going once you're on the move.

• Next, you can apply the Rule in 3 transformative ways to:

(i) Change habits and behaviors;

(ii) Master your mind; and

(iii) Act with everyday courage.



Changing Habits and Behaviors

You can use the Rule to break negative habits and form positive habits, such as improving your health, boosting productivity, and overcoming procrastination.



Improving health: Most diet or exercise programs work if you take consistent action. Unfortunately, most of us take action only when we feel like it.

• Set a personal health goal, whether it's running a marathon, daily pushups, reducing sugar intake, or going for a health checkup. Then, use the 5 Second Rule to push yourself to take action regardless of how you feel. For example:

(i) 5-4-3-2-1-GO and choose a healthier snack: turn away from the donut and pick up a piece of fruit instead;

(ii) 5-4-3-2-1-GO and start your home workout, such as pushups, sit-ups, or jumping jacks; or

(iii) 5-4-3-2-1-GO and plan your meals for the day, ensuring they're balanced and healthy.

• Usually, the hardest part is to get started. After you take your first step, just keep going and you'll see massive results.



The 5 Second Rule also helps to improve your productivity by achieving 2 types of focus:

KEY QUOTES

"When you act with courage, your brain is not involved. Your heart speaks first and you listen. The Rule will teach you how."

"To reach your potential, you'll have to push yourself—there is no other way."

"Stop thinking about how you feel. Your feelings don't matter. The only thing that matters is what you DO."

"Exercise and health comes down to one simple rule—you don't have to feel like it. You just have to do it."

KEY QUOTES

"Interruptions of any sort are the kiss of death for your productivity."

*"Nothing will work unless you do."
—Maya Angelou*

"You'll either find a way or you'll find an excuse."

- Eliminate distractions to concentrate fully on the task at hand. Once you notice a distraction, start the countdown to remove it.
- Direct your focus to what's truly important, not on menial tasks and time-wasters. The best way to do so is to establish a *morning routine*: set your intentions and get crystal-clear on your most important tasks for the day. Robbins' routine goes like this:
 - (i) Get up when the alarm rings; don't snooze. Scientists found that hitting the snooze button can make you feel tired for hours, because you're start a new sleep cycle (which usually lasts 90-110 minutes) then interrupting it.
 - (ii) Put your alarm in the bathroom so you must get up to turn it off. As you brush your teeth, focus on the big things to do that day to make progress on your personal goals.
 - (iii) Wake up 30 minutes earlier to plan out your day. Write down the top 3 "musts" for the day and why they're important for you. Ideally, start working on the items right away, or schedule them for later in the day. Don't start replying to emails or messages until you get to the office.
 - (iv) Plan out when you'll stop working and take time to recharge yourself.



The 5 Second Rule is the perfect weapon to fight procrastination.

- Strategic procrastination can be helpful for creative processes—where you set aside a project temporarily to allow fresh ideas to surface.
- However, it's often destructive when you avoid something that needs to get done. We procrastinate not because we're lazy or undisciplined, but as a coping mechanism. By avoiding work to shop online or watch a video, we're seeking temporary stress relief and getting a boost of feel-good dopamine. Ironically, this only creates more stress as our work builds up.
- Use the 5 Second Rule to battle destructive procrastination:
 - (i) Stop beating yourself up for procrastinating so you can move forward. Do a countdown and forgive yourself.

(ii) Visualize your future self—someone successful and productive—and ask, “What would my future self do?” Then 5-4-3-2-1-Do it.

(iii) Each time you feel yourself hesitating, do the countdown and just launch into the task.



Master Your Mind

The 5 Second Rule can be used to combat persistent anxiety, worries, and fear, to help you focus on things that bring you joy instead.



For 2 decades, Robbins relied on medication to manage her anxiety. After discovering the Rule, she could habitually redirect her thoughts to positive things, improving her confidence and mental control.



Worrying is futile as it often involves events that are unlikely to happen. In any case, worrying won't prevent or solve the issue.

- The moment you start worrying, use the Rule to switch to positive thoughts, like the things you're grateful for. The more you think about the great things in your life, the less time/energy you have to worry about imaginary worst-case scenarios, and the more you can enjoy each moment in your life.



You can also use the Rule to curb anxiety, which kicks in when your worries spin out of control.

- Anxiety can escalate into panic attacks, marked by adrenaline surges and a state of hyper-alertness, even though there's no real danger. In such a state, it's ineffective to tell yourself to calm down, as your mind is frantically seeking the cause of your anxiety.
- Instead, use the 5 Second Rule to regain control of your mind and reframe the anxiety as excitement. For example, if

KEY QUOTES

"Go the extra mile. It's never crowded."

*"Rule your mind, or it will rule you."
—Horace*

"When your mind takes you somewhere sad, dark, doubtful, or negative, you don't have to go with it."

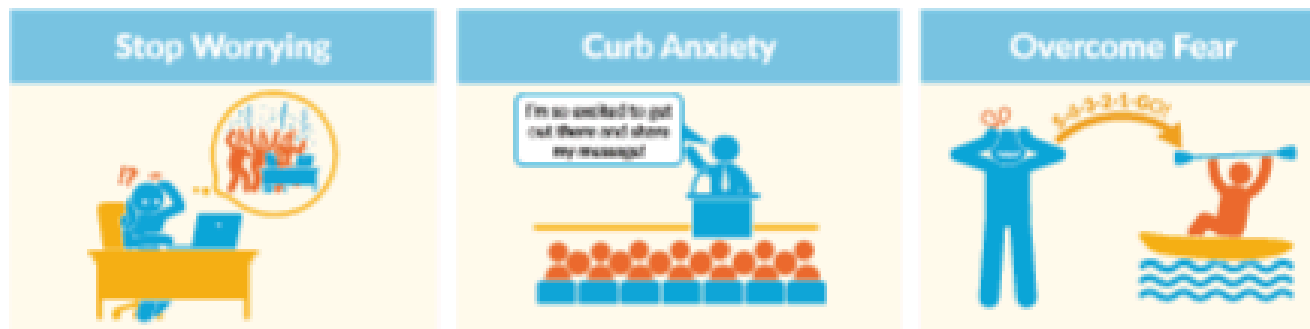
*"You are braver than you believe, stronger than you seem, and smarter than you think."
— A.A. Milne*

you feel your nerves kicking in before a public speech, do a countdown the say, "I'm so excited to get out there and share my message!" This works because anxiety and excitement feel similar to your body. By labeling anxiety as excitement, you calm your mind and turn your stress into an advantage.



Use a similar approach to overcome fear, such as the fear of flying.

- Before a trip, anchor an image of what you're excited to do once you get there.
- (i) Once you feel nervous, use the 5 Second Rule to bring up the anchor image. Your brain will calm down once it interprets the fear as excitement.
- (ii) When you do this repeatedly, the brain will stop thinking of flying as a scary event, and you'd have conquered your fear.



Act with Everyday Courage

The 5 Second Rule gives you the courage to face daily challenges, to help (i) increase your self-confidence, (ii) discover your passions, and (iii) enrich your relationships.



Confidence stems from self-belief, not personality traits. You can increase your confidence like any skill.

- According to psychologist Professor Brian Little, some personality traits are fixed, but many are adaptable to our goals and needs. Each time you use the Rule to do something that's "not like you", it gradually shifts your self-perception. For example, you might think you're not the type of person to talk to strangers. Yet, if you use the Rule to introduce yourself to 3 strangers daily, it shifts your perception of self.

KEY QUOTES

"It's okay to be scared. Being scared means you're about to do something really, really brave."

*"All our dreams can come true if we have the courage to pursue them."
- Walt Disney*

"Master your mind and anything is possible."

*"The cave you fear to enter holds the treasure you seek."
- Joseph Campbell*

"If you have the courage to take action, your confidence will follow."

"Confidence is created by the small things you do every single day that build trust in yourself."

KEY QUOTES

"The answers are inside of you if you have the courage to listen...It starts with listening to what's inside of you and ends with the courage to go where it leads."

"Don't tell people your dreams. Show them."

*"An act of courage is always an act of love."
- Paulo Coelho*

"Intimacy takes courage."

"Speak from your heart, even if your voice shakes."

- The more you use the Rule to practice acts of courage, the more you feel in control of your life, and the more confident you feel.

 Use the Rule to actively explore your feelings, engage with topics that spark your interest, and progressively discover your passions.

- Notice what consistently draws your curiosity or envy, and pause to explore your underlying feelings and desires.
- Take some simple steps to learn about the topic, e.g. read up on it, watch some video tutorials, talk to people in that field, or take a class. Over time, you can learn enough to become an expert in a specific area.
- Often, discovering your passions starts with acting on an instinct, then building momentum one step at a time. At some point, you might decide to make a real commitment and turn your passion-project into a full-time career. The key is to have the courage to keep following your heart.

 The 5 Second Rule also helps to enrich your relationships. Use the Rule to overcome fears of vulnerability or conflict, freeing yourself to express your thoughts/feelings and strengthen your relationships.

- Don't leave important things unsaid. Do a countdown, then speak your mind or reach out to connect with someone. The more openly and authentically you communicate, the more your relationships will deepen and grow.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

The book is filled with testimonials and social media excerpts to show how people worldwide have been positively impacted by the 5 Second Rule. The effects range from enhancing personal health/

wellness, to improving finances, career, emotional regulation, and even overcoming addiction. For more details, please visit melrobbins.com.



About the Author

Mel Robbins is a motivational speaker, author, business coach and on-air commentator. She started her career as a criminal defense attorney before launching her own retail and Internet technology company. Robbins is the author of several best-selling books. She now leads coaching programs for various global companies, and hosts several award-winning shows. Robbins graduated from the Dartmouth College and Boston College Law School.



KEY QUOTES